



retake her effort, only to see her shot palmed away by Spain custodian Cata Coll.

The cheers from those clad in red were loud. Incidents like these, especially during a major final's shootout, can be a death knell for a team's mental resolve.

But Spain scripted its own downfall, failing to convert three spot-kicks on the trot, with Chloe Kelly (**facing page, below**) putting the final nail in the coffin.

From uncertainty to Sweet Caroline

England's EURO 2025 campaign was one of grit and determination and also a stroke of fortune, which saw it survive penalty shootouts in both the quarterfinal (against Sweden) and the final.

The tournament marked the rise of a new star in Hannah Hampton, who made two crucial saves in the final's shootout, showing a sharp presence between the sticks — a key contributor to the Lionesses' victorious run. Considering the pressure she was under, replacing a

figure like Mary Earps, her performance was all the more impressive. At the end of it all, Hampton got the deserved 'Player of the Match' award in the final.

From England's gloomy pre-EURO build-up, with players like Millie Bright and Earps ruled out, to successfully defending its title and singing *Sweet Caroline* with the fans — as per tradition — there was a distinct 'feel-good factor' about Wiegman's winning team.

Taking by surprise

There wasn't much hype around Andrea Soncin's Italy side, which faced challenging circumstances even before the tournament began. Drawn into Group B alongside Spain, Belgium, and Portugal, expectations were low — but the Italians showed resolve, qualifying from the group as runner-up.

Opening with a 1-0 win over Belgium, it drew 1-1 with Portugal, and eventually suffered a 1-3 loss to Spain.

A quarterfinal clash with Norway was a tricky one, given the latter's power-packed attack featuring the likes of Caroline Graham Hansen and Ada Hegerberg.

Hegerberg did make Italian hearts skip a beat by opening the scoring, but a brace from Cristina Girelli — including a 90th-minute winner — sent Italy into the semifinals.

If the Norway fixture was tough, the semifinal matchup seemed an almost impossible hurdle for Soncin's side as it was going up against defending champion England. A story for the ages was almost written by Italy.

Barbara Bonansea's 33rd-minute goal nearly took Italy over the finish line and into the final, but its quest was undone by 'Young Player of the Tournament', Michelle Agyemang, who grabbed an equaliser in the sixth minute of second-half stoppage time to force extra time. Kelly would go on to convert a 119th-minute penalty to win it for England.

"This is something that hurts, but we have to be proud of what we've done. The fact that we didn't get to the final — and were just one minute away is encouragement," Soncin said after the semifinal loss.

Safe bet: England keeper Hannah Hampton was adjudged Player of the Match in the final. REUTERS

